

This book is full of questions aimed at designers across all disciplines and ages of our profession, from branding to video games, from school violence to improving the environment or plagiarism. The book is broken up in the following manner:

Part I: Social Responsibility
Part II: Professional Responsibility
Part III: Artistic Responsibility
Part IV: Raves and Rants

In every section we find dissatisfied designers, or individuals in the design profession who are questioning the way things are done, or who have found a better way of doing things, and they have a good reason to expect change from you and their peers.

Katherine McCoy finds that many designers practice self-censorship and do not address or communicate in public issues or controversial content, either by fear or disinterest. In an interview by Heller, Milton Glaser talks about his update to the I ♥ NY logo following September 11th. Judith Shwartz questions the growing form of corporate sponsorship, while Maud Lavin addresses design criticism.

While the subjects are many, they seem to overlap in several occasions (First Things First Manifesto) and seem to be primarily focused to the US. I wish more debate and information regarding public service, by which I mean signage, consumer labels or emergency communications was covered.

Designers are usually predisposed to produce good-looking work, but after reading this book you might think that good design is in actuality, responsible design. Unfortunately, this book is not a springboard towards action for designers.

“In the most fundamental sense, then, responsibility is the ability to respond, not just the willingness to act, but also the ability to understand one’s actions, the context in which they are applied, and the widest range of implications for their reception and potential reinterpretation.”

— Anne Bush

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STEVEN HELLER & VÉRONIQUE VIENNE

CITIZEN DESIGNER

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PERSPECTIVES ON DESIGN RESPONSIBILITY

*Can a designer effect political and/or social change?
What does it mean to be a responsible designer?
What does it mean to be design conscious?*

Steven Heller and Véronique Vienne don’t really answer these questions, but they do provide some clues in Citizen Designer.

Through essays by:

Hugh Aldersey-Williams, Julie Baugnet, Leslie Becker, Roy R. Behrens, Nancy Bernard, J.D. Biersdorfer, Anne Bush, Robbie Conal, Michael Dooley, Stuart Ewen, Thomas Frank, Ken Garland, Peter Hall, Mr. Keedy, Maud Lavin, Victor Margolin, Carolyn McCarron, Katherine McCoy, David Reinfurt, Chris Riley, Chase A. Rogers, Michael Schmidt, Judith Schwartz, Matt Soar, Gunnar Swanson, Susan S. Szenasy, Teal Triggs, Tucker Viemeister, David Vogler, and Cheryl Towler Weese. And interviews with Fabrizio Gilardino, Milton Glaser, Kalle Lasn, Robert Menard, Don Norman, Mark Randall, David Sterling, Stanley Tigerman, and Shawn Wolfe. (That’s a lot of people!).

Graphic designers have the power to influence people — by designing the products they buy, the magazines they read, the information they receive to vote, what they shop for, and in many more ways than most are aware of. What they design has a strong social repercussion in the every-day world of hundreds, thousands or even millions of people (think I ♥ NY by Milton Glaser). What they do for a living every day, can and will impact at least one life.

What does it mean to be a designer in this corporate-driven, over-branded, global consumer culture? Who are designers responsible to? Who do these designers work for? Are they researching clients, making sure these are not fraudulent, polluting or abusing? Do they still work for them? Do they take a stand? Or figure bills need to be paid? What is responsible design?